

PHIL1034 - Final Essay

Essay 4: Suppose one day, a group of aliens – more intelligent and just as sentient and emotionally rich as us – arrives on planet Earth. Do we possess moral obligations to treat them as equals? What does your answer imply for socioeconomic arrangements on Earth?

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“Most humans are speciesist,” declared Peter Singer in his work *Animal Liberation* while defending the rights of animals, which are too often violated simply because they are not human. According to the philosopher, it is this same logic that leads to racism and sexism, where mere physical characteristics justify differences in treatment. The key difference raised by the question lies in the fact that these aliens are not only as sentient and emotionally rich as humans, but also more intelligent, meaning that they possess the same autonomy and capacity for reasoning. Thus, this essay will start by explaining why the rights of these aliens should be respected, before examining whether humans should treat them as equals, despite the “speciesist” bias, by considering characteristics of human nature as studied by Mencius and Xunzi. The study will then extend to Tianxia, “All under Heaven”, also present in Laozi’s *Daodejing*, arguing that by treating these aliens as equals, humans could fulfill their role as co-participants in the world, beyond earth. Finally, the fact that these aliens would be more intelligent than humans raises the existential risks they could pose, which could lead humans to take decisions ranging from exploiting them within socioeconomic structures to preemptively eliminating them for self-defense.

One of the foundations this essay will lay, before considering whether humans should treat aliens as equals, is that their rights deserve to be respected because, like animals and humans, they are sentient beings capable of “suffering”, as would be argued by Singer.¹ Indeed, despite having unknown physical characteristics which could imply different levels of physical pain and pleasure, being as emotionally rich as humans means they would also suffer psychologically. Thus, applying the philosopher’s principle of equality, it is the nature of the beings and their interests that must be considered. Compared to Singer’s statement that “dogs, on the other hand, are incapable of understanding the significance of voting, so they cannot have the right to vote,”² these aliens, being more intelligent than humans, would possess that understanding. Thus, following Peter Singer’s reasoning, similar capacities would lead humans to be morally obligated to treat these aliens as equals.

On the other hand, going beyond intelligence as the sole factor, it is essential to question what it means to be human. This also requires examining our duties toward humans and animals, which will be done through Confucian ethics. It could be argued that humans’ moral obligations toward these aliens depend on the resemblance between their natures: whether they possess a sense of right and wrong, are attached to principles of justice, and how their society is organized. For instance, Mencius argued that humans have a good nature, shaped by incipient virtuous inclinations, or “sprouts”. After showing that anyone faced with a child about to fall into a well would feel compassion, he summarizes human nature through four virtues: “if one is without the heart of compassion, one is not a human. If one is without the heart of disdain, one is not a human. If one is without the heart of deference, one is not a human. If one is without the heart of approval and disapproval, one is not a human.”³ While Mencius saw these virtues as innate, Xunzi argued that human nature is bad and that these virtues must be developed through learning and rituals: “People’s nature is bad. Their goodness is a matter of deliberate effort.”⁴ Thus, whether aliens would be capable of embodying these virtues, innately or through effort, could shape how humans treat them.

¹Peter Singer, *Animal Liberation*, page 7. Singer partly derived his analysis from Jeremy Bentham’s famous quote “The question is not, Can they reason? not Can they talk, but, Can they suffer?” when the utilitarian urged the British to abolish slavery, as the French had done

²Peter Singer, *Animal Liberation*, page 2

³*Mengzi*, 2A6

⁴*Xunzi*, Chapter 23

Following the advice of Mencius, who explains that to develop one's nature basic needs such as food must be met,⁵ or of Xunzi that learning thanks to sages setting up an example of these virtues is necessary, would entail a dignified treatment of these aliens. Likewise, Mencius acknowledges that some humans fail to be "good" due to a harmful environment⁶ which could further support respecting aliens' rights.

Meanwhile, Fan Ruiping provides guidance on humans' moral obligations toward animals through Confucian ethics, which is useful when considering aliens, by differentiating three kinds of love. The first is devotional, owed to one's parents as part of the principle of 'Li', followed by benevolence toward people, 'Ren', and finally sympathetic love for animals, which involves caring for them.⁷ Addressing the apparent contradiction between loving animals and killing them, the philosopher argues that sacrifices and consumption were part of ritual duties, while unnecessary suffering should be avoided.⁸ First, this hierarchy of love reflects Mencius's idea that humans naturally prioritize their family,⁹ as opposed to Mohist impartial caring. This suggests that the "speciesist" approach decried by Singer would apply here, as, despite their autonomy, aliens would not be included within the human species. Following this logic, should their treatment stand between sympathetic and benevolent love, as their autonomy places them above animals but below humans? A second implication of their autonomy is that it would be immoral to kill them, as with innocent humans, and that they could not be used as mere means in rituals like animals. This has important socioeconomic consequences, as it would not allow humans to integrate these aliens into society solely to serve their interests. Thus, even if they aren't treated as equals, a form of co-existence must take place that would respect their interests.

Until now, the analysis has been conducted through an anthropocentric view, and changes when recalling that Earth and humans represent only a small share of the universe. Accordingly, Daoism and the concept of "Tianxia" will be examined to determine whether humans should be morally obligated to treat aliens as equals. Drawing from *Daodejing*, it is essential to study the terms employed by Laozi – and their relationships – when the principles of non-action and unity with the universe are outlined: "Humans model Earth, Earth models Heaven, Heaven models the Dao, and the Dao models ziran."¹⁰ Within this cosmological reasoning, which aims at embracing the natural harmony of the Way, aliens would fit as part of "Heaven" ('Tian'), a manifestation of the Way. Since Earth – and by extension humans – must model themselves on 'Tian', this would entail, given the aliens' autonomy, treating them as equals. The idea that disciples of the Way "work with the myriad creatures and turn none away"¹¹ provides an explicit reference to creatures other than humans. In this scenario, it would provide an opportunity for humans to achieve unity with the cosmos, whose balance would require respecting aliens' rights and treating them as equals.¹²

⁵ Mengzi, 7A27

⁶ Mengzi, 6A8

⁷ Fan Ruiping, *How Should We Treat Animals? A Confucian Reflection*, page 81. By caring for them, the philosopher means that one should not eat the animals that have labored for us or the pets that have accompanied us, the latter deserving to be buried when they die.

⁸ Fan Ruiping, *How Should We Treat Animals? A Confucian Reflection*, page 87

⁹ Mengzi, 7A15

¹⁰ Laozi, *Daodejing*, Book One, Chapter 25

¹¹ Laozi, *Daodejing*, Book One, Chapter 2

¹² Similarly, although Confucius did not have the same conception of the Way, in *All under Heaven* (page 8), Zhao Tingyang, suggests that the "world that Confucius envisioned recognizes a plurality of different ways of life, seeking diversity and pluralism as ideals without requiring uniformity" referring to the following passage from *Zhongyong* (chapter 30), attributed to Zisi, "Just as heaven and earth do not fail in conveying

This argument is further developed by Tingyang's vision of a world order under "Tianxia". His analysis applies to international politics, whose current theories he criticizes for promoting a logic of conflict. He suggests shifting from division to a world-internalized co-existence, and from individual to relational rationality that considers all actors' interests, resulting in a system where "by transforming everything external to internal, it prevents the existence of aliens."¹³ This approach, applied to the universe, could lead to a positive and equal co-existence between aliens and humans.

However, Tingyang also claims that the only rational war is that of self-defense.¹⁴ Thus, faced with aliens capable of driving the human race to extinction due to their higher intelligence and potential misalignment, wouldn't humans be morally obliged to protect themselves? Paradoxically, if such a scenario materialized, constant conflict between states could transform into unity in the face of a common enemy. To answer this question, aspects of Confucianism and Daoism will be reconsidered. As mentioned, the principle of 'Li' imposes duties toward elders and gods through rituals, which, if threatened, could justify extreme actions – undermining any obligation to treat aliens as equals. One could argue that in response to this decision the cardinal principles of benevolence and wisdom would enter in conflict since humans would have the moral discernment to realize that this act could be fundamentally wrong, comparable to a genocide at the human level – yet they still take place. Daoism, by contrast, emphasizes unity within the universe, and would be less likely to endorse such actions, instead encouraging humans to seek peace with aliens. Laozi would likely suggest that aliens also have a duty to follow the Way, making a peaceful relationship between the two species possible.

Taking a more realistic approach, the decision to hedge against this risk could depend on the aliens' behavior and the level of political cooperation between the two species. However, this approach could be morally flawed, as it would imply an abstract limit beyond which irreversible decisions about the treatment of aliens could be made. Similarly, this would require maintaining control over aliens within the socioeconomic structure, neglecting their intelligence and autonomy, which, as for humans, are essential to achieving their potential.

In conclusion, the sentience of these aliens provides reasons to respect their rights, while their autonomy suggests that humans could be morally obliged to treat them as equals. This conclusion can be approached through two dimensions: one linked to the nature of humans and aliens, and another considering that both belong to the same universe, where they could be united as followers of the Dao. However, the existential risk they could pose raises the question of whether humans could adopt means that would otherwise be considered immoral in order to ensure their own survival.

anything or sheltering anything. . . . the myriad things are nourished together and don't harm each other."

¹³Zhao Tingyang, *All under Heaven, The Tianxia system for a possible world order*

¹⁴Zhao Tingyang, *All under Heaven, The Tianxia system for a possible world order*, page 25

Bibliography

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